FREE RESOURCE FROM PRADIPTA DAS

Website Launch Checklist

Launches rarely go wrong on the big things. They go wrong on a forgotten redirect, a noindex tag left over from staging or an analytics tag that never fired. Work through this list a week before launch, then again on the day and the week after. It works for any platform: WordPress, Shopify, Next.js or anything else.

01 Technical SEO

Most launch-day ranking drops come from settings carried over from staging. Check the live site, not staging.

- [ ] **No page is set to noindex.**
  Look for `<meta name="robots" content="noindex">` and an `X-Robots-Tag: noindex` header. In WordPress, untick Settings › Reading › "Discourage search engines".
- [ ] **robots.txt doesn't block the site.**
  No `Disallow: /` left over from staging, and a `Sitemap:` line pointing to the live sitemap.
- [ ] **The XML sitemap lists only live, indexable pages.**
  Every URL in it should return 200, be canonical and not be noindexed.
- [ ] **Canonical tags point to the live domain.**
  Not to staging, and each indexable page points to itself.
- [ ] **One address for the whole site.**
  http to https and www to non-www (or the reverse) in a single 301 redirect, not a chain.
- [ ] **Every page has its own title and meta description.**
  Titles of roughly 50–60 characters, and one H1 per page.
- [ ] **Structured data passes Google's Rich Results Test.**
  Organisation or Person, breadcrumbs, articles, products: whichever the site uses.
- [ ] **Shared links look right.**
  Paste a few URLs into a messaging app or social post to check the share image and title.
- [ ] **No links point to the staging domain.**
  Search the database or the codebase for the staging address before launch.

02 Redirects and 404s

Every old URL with links or traffic should land somewhere useful on the new site.

- [ ] **List every URL on the old site.**
  Combine a crawl, the old sitemap, your top landing pages in analytics and the pages in Search Console.
- [ ] **Map each old URL to its closest new page.**
  Use 301 (permanent) redirects, not 302. Send a page to the home page only when nothing closer exists.

- [ ] **No redirect chains or loops.**
  A redirects straight to C, never A to B to C.
- [ ] **The 404 page returns a real 404 status.**
  Not a 200 "soft 404". Give it navigation or search so visitors can recover.
- [ ] **Update the links you control elsewhere.**
  Google Business Profile, social profiles, email signatures, ads and directory listings.

03 Page speed and Core Web Vitals

Test the main templates (home, a content page, a listing, a product or form page) on mobile in PageSpeed Insights.

- [ ] **Core Web Vitals are in the "good" range.**
  Largest Contentful Paint 2.5 s or less, Interaction to Next Paint 200 ms or less, Cumulative Layout Shift 0.1 or less.
- [ ] **Images are sized and compressed.**
  WebP or AVIF, no larger than they're shown, with width and height set so the layout doesn't jump.
- [ ] **The main image above the fold loads first.**
  Don't lazy-load it; lazy-load the images further down instead.
- [ ] **Fonts are kept in check.**
  A few families and weights, `font-display: swap`, and preload only the fonts above the fold.
- [ ] **Caching is on.**
  A page cache or CDN for HTML, and long cache lifetimes for CSS, JavaScript and images.
- [ ] **Third-party scripts have earned their place.**
  Remove the ones nobody uses, and load the rest after the page or after consent.
- [ ] **Unused plugins, apps and themes are removed.**
  Deactivated is not enough: delete them.

04 Accessibility basics

Automated tools such as Lighthouse, axe or WAVE find only part of the problems. Do a keyboard pass yourself as well.

- [ ] **Text contrast meets WCAG AA.**
  At least 4.5:1 for body text and 3:1 for large text.
- [ ] **Headings follow a logical order.**
  One H1, then H2s and H3s that outline the page. Never pick a heading for its size.
- [ ] **Images have the right alt text.**
  Describe the images that carry information; give decorative ones an empty `alt=""`.
- [ ] **Everything works with a keyboard.**
  Menus, forms, sliders and pop-ups, with a visible focus outline and a skip link.

- [ ] **Form fields have visible labels.**
  Errors say what went wrong and how to fix it, in text rather than colour alone.
- [ ] **Link text describes where it goes.**
  "Read the case study", not "click here".
- [ ] **The page language is set.**
  `<html lang="en">`, or the right language for the site.
- [ ] **The layout holds up when zoomed.**
  Readable at 200% zoom and at 320 px wide without scrolling sideways.
- [ ] **Videos have captions, and nothing plays sound on its own.**

05 Analytics, consent and tracking

- [ ] **Analytics records the live domain.**
  Visit the site and watch for yourself in the real-time report. Exclude or filter out staging.
- [ ] **Each conversion is tracked once.**
  Form submissions, purchases, sign-ups and phone clicks: test each one and check it isn't counted twice.
- [ ] **Consent works where the law requires it.**
  In the UK and EU, non-essential cookies and tags load only after the visitor agrees, and the choice is remembered.
- [ ] **The privacy policy matches what the site collects.**
  Including every analytics, advertising and embedded service.
- [ ] **The site is verified in Search Console and Bing Webmaster Tools.**
  Use a Domain property in Search Console. Bing can import it from Google.
- [ ] **Ad and pixel conversions are tested.**
  Use each platform's own test or debug tool.
- [ ] **The launch date is noted in analytics.**
  So any change in the numbers can be traced back to it.

06 Forms and emails

- [ ] **Every form works on the live domain.**
  Submit each one on a phone and a desktop.
- [ ] **Notifications reach the right inbox.**
  And not its spam folder. Send a test from an outside address.
- [ ] **Email is sent from your own domain and authenticated.**
  SPF, DKIM and DMARC records in place for the domain that appears in the From address.
- [ ] **Automatic emails have the right links and branding.**
  Order confirmations, password resets and replies point to the live site, not staging.

- [ ] **Spam protection doesn't stop real people.**
  Honeypot fields, rate limits or a CAPTCHA, tested with a normal submission.
- [ ] **For online stores: a real order goes all the way through.**
  Pay with a real card, check tax, shipping and the emails, then refund it.

07 Security, SSL and backups

- [ ] **The SSL certificate covers every version of the domain.**
  Both www and non-www, renewing automatically, with no mixed-content warnings.
- [ ] **Admin accounts are locked down.**
  Strong, unique passwords and two-factor sign-in; delete staging and unused accounts.
- [ ] **Core software, themes and plugins are up to date.**
- [ ] **Basic security headers are set.**
  `Strict-Transport-Security` once HTTPS is stable, `X-Content-Type-Options: nosniff` and a `Referrer-Policy`.
- [ ] **The staging site is password-protected or deleted.**
  A public copy of the site competes with it in search.
- [ ] **A full backup is taken just before launch and stored off the server.**
  Files and database, and you've checked that a restore works.
- [ ] **There's a rollback plan.**
  Who does what, and how to switch back within an hour if something breaks.
- [ ] **Uptime monitoring is on.**
  So you hear about an outage before your visitors do.

08 Launch day

- [ ] **Lower the DNS TTL a day ahead.**
  So the switch takes minutes rather than hours. Leave the MX records alone so email keeps working.
- [ ] **Freeze content changes on the old site.**
- [ ] **Switch over, then clear every cache.**
  Server, CDN and any page-cache plugin.
- [ ] **Run a smoke test on mobile and desktop.**
  Home page, key pages, every form, checkout, search and the 404 page.
- [ ] **Check for noindex and robots.txt once more, on the live site.**
- [ ] **Submit the sitemap in Search Console.**
  And request indexing for the home page.
- [ ] **Keep the old hosting until everything has moved.**
  DNS changes can take a while to reach everyone.

09 The week after

- [ ] **Check Search Console for crawl errors and 404s.**
  Add redirects for any old URLs you missed.
- [ ] **Compare traffic and conversions with the weeks before.**
  Look at the top landing pages one by one.
- [ ] **Watch the server error logs.**
- [ ] **Re-run the speed tests.**
  Field data from real visitors in PageSpeed Insights covers the last 28 days, so it catches up over the first month.
- [ ] **Set up regular, automatic backups.**
  And note when to check that a restore still works.

Launching something soon?

I'm happy to look over your launch plan or run through this list with you on a free call: pradipta.online/free-consultation.